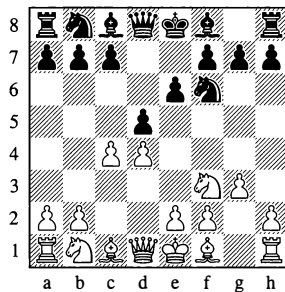


Chapter 1

Catalan



Introduction

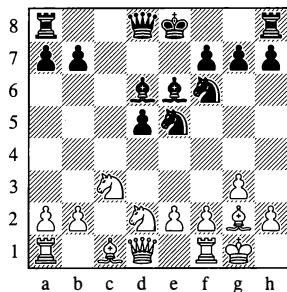
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5

4.♘f3

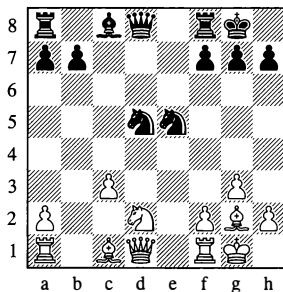
A) 4...g6 5.♗g2 ♗g7 6.0-0 0-0 7.♖c2	8
A1) 7...♘c6	9
A2) 7...♘a6	9
A3) 7...♘bd7	10
B) 4...c6 5.♗g2 ♘bd7 6.0-0 ♗d6 7.♘fd2! 0-0 8.♘c3	11
B1) 8...♖e8	12
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C1) 5...♗e7	14
C2) 5...♘c6 6.0-0	18
C21) 6...♗e7	18
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B) note to 7...0-0



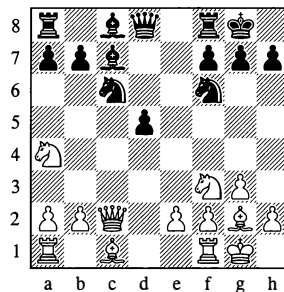
11.♘b3!N

B2) note to 10...d4!N



14.♘b3!N

C1) after 11...♗c7



12.♗e3!N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♙f3

This is our starting position for the Catalan, which is the primary topic of this book. In this chapter we will analyse three options that I neglected to mention in *GM 1*: A) 4...g6, B) 4...c6 and C) 4...c5.

A) 4...g6

This looks like an odd choice, but it has been played quite a lot in recent years, including by some strong grandmasters.

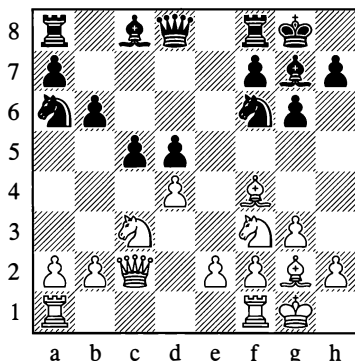
5.♙g2

Initially I was drawn to 5.b3!? with the idea to develop the bishop to a3, but I soon realized that 5...dxc4!N 6.bxc4 c5 offers Black interesting play.

5...♙g7 6.0-0 0-0 7.♖c2

From this position Black can arrange his pieces in all kinds of ways, but I have focused on the three knight developments: A1) 7...♘c6, A2) 7...♘a6 and A3) 7...♘bd7. A couple of other ideas include:

7...b6 8.cxd5 exd5 9.♙f4 ♘a6 10.♘c3 c5 leads to an interesting version of a Queen's Indian, with the bishop on g7 instead of e7.



11.♙fd1N (The premature 11.dxc5?! occurred in Unapkoshvili – Kobeshavidze, Batumi 2010, when 11...bxc5N would have been

fine for Black; 11.♙ad1!?N could also be considered) 11...♙b7 12.♙e5± The same position is reached at the end of variation A2 below.

7...c6

This position has occurred many times in practice, but I was surprised to see that hardly anyone has played:

8.♙f4!?

The more popular 8.♘bd2 ♘bd7 9.e4 dxe4 10.♘xe4 ♘xe4 11.♙xe4 has achieved terrific results for White, but after 11...♙e8∞ the situation seems rather double-edged to me.

8...b6N

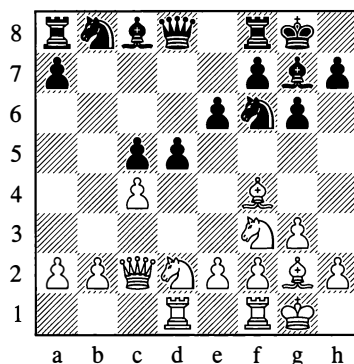
This is the most logical reply, and a definite improvement over 8...♘h5?!, when 9.♙g5 ♙f6 10.♙xf6 ♘xf6 11.♘bd2 obviously favoured White in Boege – Azzi, corr. 2014.

9.♘bd2 c5

9...♙b7 10.e4 dxe4 11.♘xe4 ♘xe4 12.♙xe4 ♘d7 13.♙ad1± gives White a pleasant space advantage.

10.dxc5 bxc5 11.♙ad1

White has a promising position, for instance:

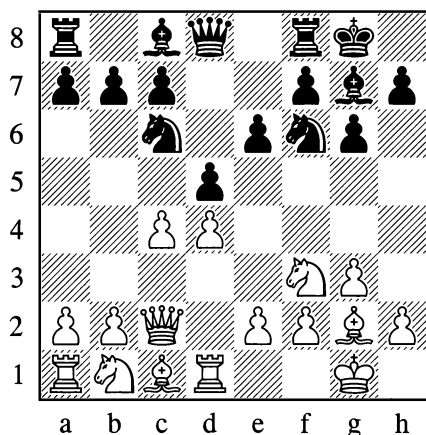


11...♘bd7 12.e4 ♙b7 13.♙fe1! dxe4 13...d4 14.♙d6 would be annoying for Black.

14.♘g5

White is in good shape, as he will recapture the pawn while keeping a better structure.

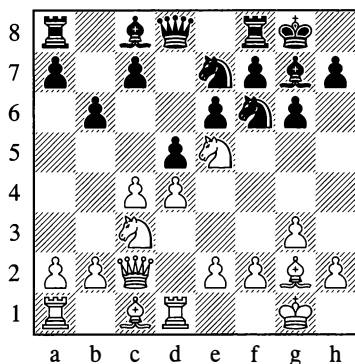
A1) 7...♖c6 8.♗d1



8...♗e4

Black intends to exchange a pair of knights.

Another idea is: 8...♗e7 9.♗c3 b6 10.♗e5 (10.e4 dxe4 11.♗xe4 ♗xe4 12.♖xe4 ♖b8∞ followed by ...♗b7 is not so clear)



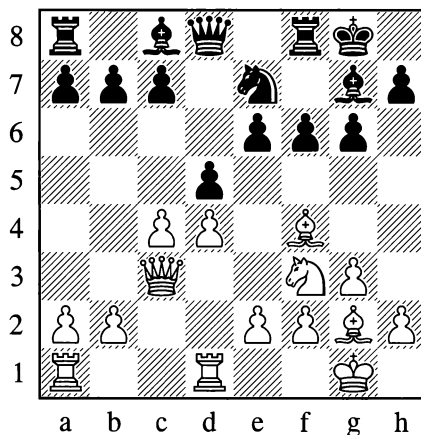
10...♗b7 11.cxd5 exd5N This looks natural. (The only game went 11...♗fxd5, Kekki – Merriman, London 1989, and now the obvious 12.e4 ♗xc3 13.bxc3± would have given White the better game) 12.b4 c6 13.a4± White has the more comfortable side of a complex game.

9.♗c3 ♗xc3 10.♖xc3 ♗e7

I was surprised to see that the Bosnian grandmaster Bojan Kurajica has defended this position against three opponents, all of whom chose different moves. My personal preference is:

11.♗f4 f6

Now I would like to propose an improvement over Tukmakov – Kurajica, Cetinje 1991.



12.♖c2N b6

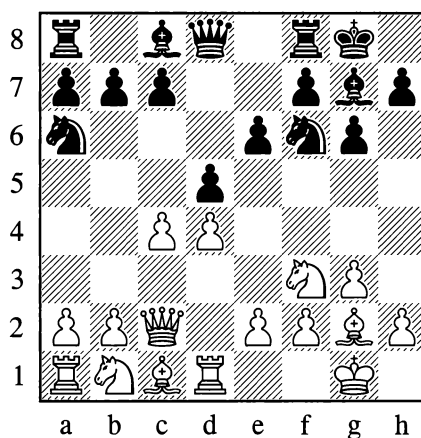
12...c6 13.e4 obviously looks great for White.

13.♖ac1 ♗b7 14.cxd5 ♗xd5 15.♗e1 ♖c8 16.♗d3 ♖e7 17.♖c4

White enjoys a stable edge.

A2) 7...♗a6 8.♗d1

8.a3 has been played more frequently, but it is hardly necessary, as ...♗b4 is not a threat just now.



8...b6

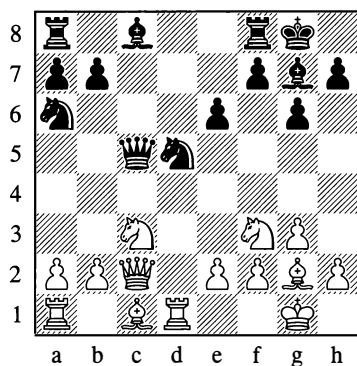
White is ready for the Grünfeld-like approach:

8...c5N 9.dxc5 ♖a5 10.♟c3! ♜xc5

Or 10...dxc4 11.♟f4 ♟d5 12.♟d6 ♜d8
13.♟d2! with the better game for White.

11.cxd5 ♟xd5

11...exd5? 12.♟e3± is unpleasant for Black.



12.♜b3 ♟xc3

12...♜b4 13.♟d2 ♜xb3 14.axb3± White retains annoying pressure.

13.bxc3 ♜xc3 14.♜xc3 ♟xc3 15.♞b1 ♟g7
16.♟a3 ♞e8 17.♟g5

Black is doomed to a passive defence and White can play for two results.

9.cxd5N

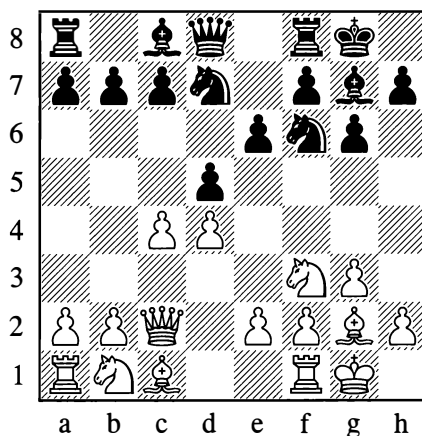
This natural novelty improves over 9.a3 c5 10.♟c3 ♟b7∞ as in Recuero Guerra – Narciso Dublan, Don Benito 2012, when the position resembles the main line below, but a2-a3 is a redundant move.

9...exd5

White would be happy to see 9...♟xd5? 10.e4 ♟db4 11.♜e2±.

10.♟c3 ♟b7 11.♟f4 c5 12.♟e5±

The position is complex, but I like White's chances against the potentially hanging pawns, and the bishop on e5 does a good job of neutralizing its counterpart on g7.

A3) 7...♟bd7**8.♟f4 c6**

I also considered:

8...b6 9.♟c3N

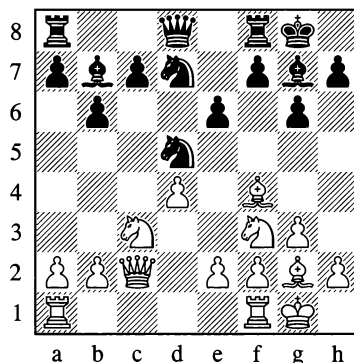
The tempting 9.cxd5 led to success for White in Ortega Hermida – Perez Castellano, Gran Canaria 2009, but things would not have been so clear after 9...♟xd5N, intending 10.♟g5 ♜e8! (10...f6? 11.♜c6! wins material) 11.e4 ♟b4 12.♜xc7 ♟a6 with a lot of counterplay.

9...♟b7 10.cxd5!

This is a more favourable moment to release the tension.

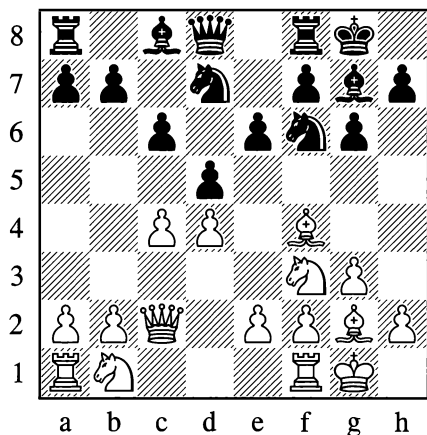
10...♟xd5

10...exd5? is bad in view of 11.♟b5±.



11.♟xd5 ♟xd5 12.e4 ♟b7 13.♞ad1

White is obviously better.



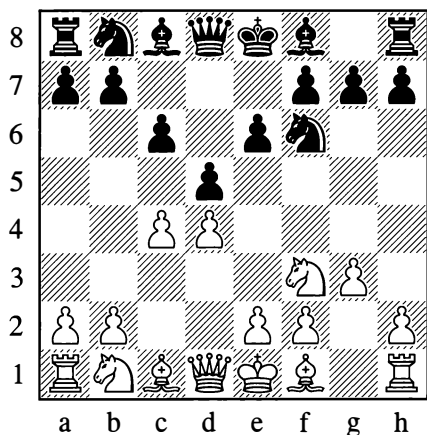
9. ♖bd2 ♜e8

9...♜e7 10.e4 h6 11.c5± was great for White in Hübner – Schmittziel, Germany 1993,

10. ♜fd1 ♜h5 11. ♙d6 ♜f5 12. e3±

In Srebrnic – S. Nikolic, Ptuj 2009, White had a pleasant position against the Stonewall formation, with an easy plan of attacking on the queenside.

B) 4...c6



I neglected to mention this option in *GM 1*, although I did rectify the oversight by publishing an update on the Quality Chess website. The text move might quickly transpose to a line examined elsewhere in the

book, but it may also prepare a Closed Catalan set-up with the bishop on d6 instead of e7.

5. ♙g2 ♜bd7

5...dxc4 leads straight to Chapter 3.

6.0–0 ♙d6

6...dxc4 transposes to variation B of Chapter 5, while 6...♙e7 7. ♜c2 0–0 takes us to variation B2 of Chapter 15.

7. ♜fd2!

A small refinement. In the aforementioned update I recommended 7. ♜c3 0–0 8. ♜d2!, but if White opts for that move order he should reckon with the possibility of 7...dxc4.

7...0–0

The only real way for Black to question White's last move is:

7...e5

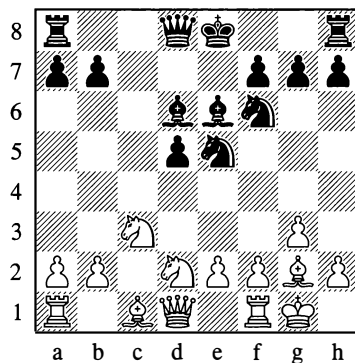
This looks slightly premature, even though it was played by Radjabov.

8.cxd5 cxd5

8...♜xd5N 9. ♜c4 ♙c7 10. ♜c3 ♜xc3 11.bxc3 looks great for White.

9.dxe5 ♜xe5 10. ♜c3 ♙e6

We have been following Grischuk – Radjabov, Moscow 2012, and here White should have played:



11. ♜b3!N

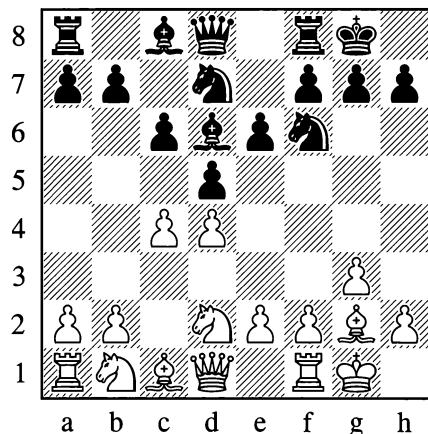
This definitely looks like a favourable position against the IQP, for instance:

11...♙b4

11...0-0?! 12.♙g5 wins a pawn.

12.♙f4 ♖c6 13.♙c1 0-0 14.♙d3

White has a nice positional edge.



8.♖c3

Many moves have been tried here, but in most cases White simply plays e2-e4 with an easy game. We will look at the most popular **B1) 8...♙e8** followed by the slightly more challenging **B2) 8...♙b4**.

Here is a brief example of a line where White gets an easy advantage:

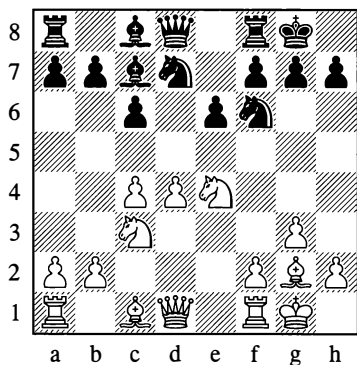
8...♙c7 9.e4 dxe4

9...dxc4 10.♖xc4 e5 11.d5 ♖b6 12.♖e3!

The knight is perfectly placed here. 12...♙e7 13.b3 White had a pleasant advantage in Evans – Zielinski, email 2010.

10.♖dxe4

White is clearly better. One model example continued:



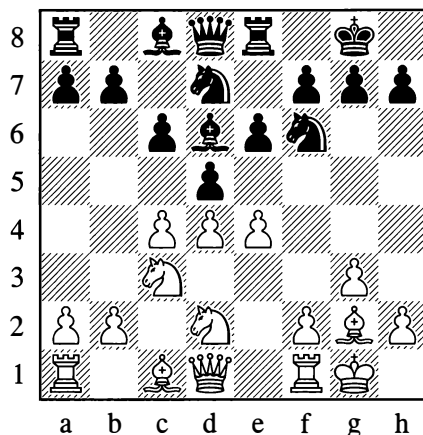
10...h6 11.♖xf6†

11.f4!? has also been played, and is a worthy alternative.

11...♖xf6 12.♙e3 e5 13.d5! cxd5 14.♖xd5 ♖xd5 15.♙xd5 ♙e7 16.♙f3±

Despite the simplifications, White's advantage was obvious in Koziak – Nalbantoglu, Izmir 2013.

B1) 8...♙e8 9.e4



9...dxe4

Black is not ready to strike in the centre with 9...e5?! in view of 10.exd5 cxd5 (or 10...exd4 11.♖ce4 ♖xe4 12.♖xe4 ♙e5 13.♖g5! with a strong initiative) 11.♖xd5 exd4 12.♖f3 ♖xd5 13.cxd5± when the d4-pawn is falling, Sundararajan – Prakash, Calcutta 2008.

10.♖dxe4 ♖xe4 11.♖xe4 ♙e7 12.♙f4 ♖f6 13.♖c3!

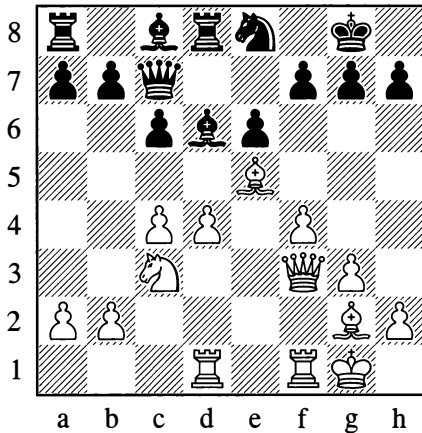
By avoiding the unnecessary exchange, White obtains a dream advantage, and the c8-bishop will remain passive for a long time.

13...♙d6 14.♙e5!

This is an important detail, which is worth remembering in similar positions. White is much better, and I will mention a recent example.

14...♖c7 15.f4 ♜d8 16.♗f3 ♞e8 17.♞ad1

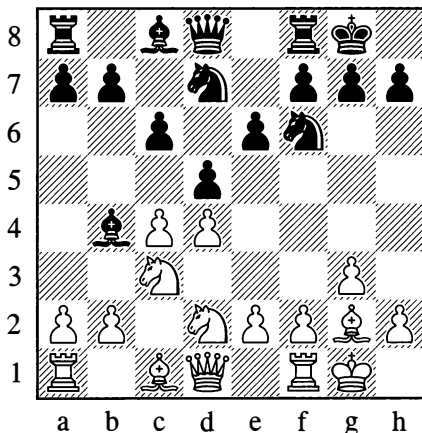
17.c5N ♜xe5 18.dxe5 also gives White a big advantage. The text move sets a positional trap, into which Black now falls.



17...f6? 18.c5! ♜xe5 19.fxexf5 20.♞e4!

With the knight coming to d6 next, White had a crushing advantage in Jakovenko – Rydstrom, Gibraltar 2015.

B2) 8...♞b4



This seems like the only move that demands any real accuracy from White.

9.e4

9.♗b3 a5 is less clear in view of 10.e4N e5!, but the text move is simple and strong.

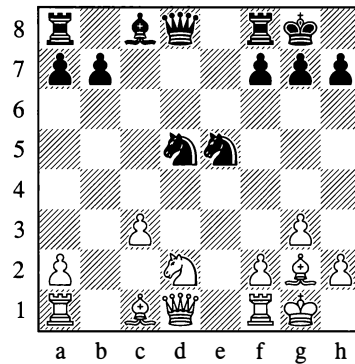
9...e5

The only serious alternative that I would like to mention is 9...♜xc3 10.bxc3 dxe4 11.♞xe4 ♞xe4 12.♜xe4 e5 as occurred in Olszewski – Hadzimanolis, Peristeri 2010. Here I propose 13.♜c2N, for instance 13...♞e8 14.♞e1 exd4 15.♞xe8+ ♗xe8 16.cxd4 ♞f6 17.♜g5 when White's bishop pair gives him excellent chances.

10.dxe5 d4!N

This new move seems like an interesting try for Black.

10...♞xe5 11.cxd5 ♜xc3 12.bxc3 cxd5 13.exd5 ♞xd5 was played in Filippov – Tunik, Novgorod 1995, when White failed to choose the best knight move:



14.♞b3!N ♜e6 (Obviously the c3-pawn is untouchable: 14...♞xc3?? 15.♗e1! and Black loses one of his knights) 15.♞e1 ♗f6 16.♗e2! ♞c6 17.♞b2 White's bishop pair should be a telling factor in the long run.

11.♞d5

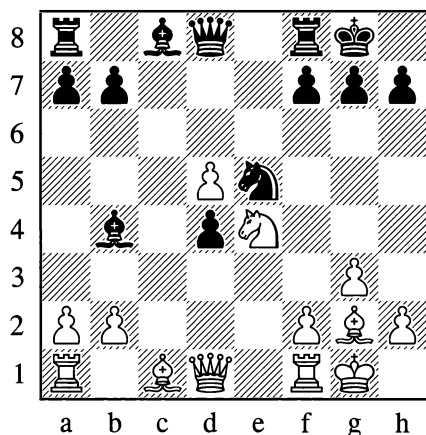
Another interesting continuation is: 11.exf6 dxc3 12.fxg7 cxd2 13.gxf8=♗+ ♞xf8! Otherwise Black is just lost. 14.a3 ♜a5 15.b4 dxc1=♗ 16.♗xc1 ♜c7 17.♗e3 The position is extremely complex, but it seems to me that White has the better prospects, as he is slightly ahead on material and has an easy plan of advancing with f2-f4 and e4-e5.

11...♟xd5 12.exd5

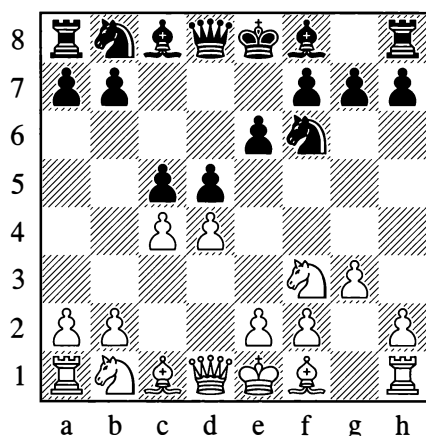
12.cxd5 ♟xe5 13.♟b3 d3 seems less convincing.

12...♟xe5

12...cxd5 13.♟f3 dxc4 14.♚xd4 ♟b6 15.♙e3± leaves White strongly centralized.

13.♟e4 cxd5 14.cxd5**14...♚b6 15.a3 ♙e7 16.♙f4 f6 17.b4±**

White's chances are definitely preferable.

C) 4...c5

This is another option that I forgot to cover in my previous 1.d4 volumes. It is not the most

popular move order in Grandmaster practice, although I noticed that Aronian won some recent games with it.

5.♙g2

5.cxd5 exd5 leads to a Tarrasch Defence, but I intend to recommend something other than the g2-g3 variation against that opening, as you will see in Volume 1B. (Black also has the independent alternatives of 5...♟xd5 and 5...cxd4!?).

Black has two main continuations: C1) 5...♙e7 and C2) 5...♟c6.

6...dxc4 leads to a branch of the Catalan which is covered in Chapters 6 and 7.

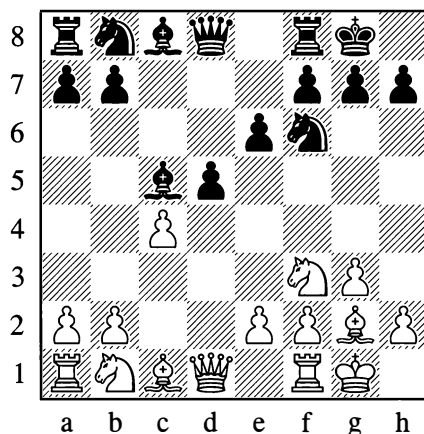
5...cxd4 6.0-0 is also likely to transpose elsewhere. 6...♟c6 reaches the later variation C22, while 6...dxc4 leads to variation A of Chapter 6 on page 74.

C1) 5...♙e7

This move order was recommended by Aagaard and Ntirlis in *Grandmaster Repertoire 10 – The Tarrasch Defence* (abbreviated to *GM 10* from now on).

6.0-0 0-0 7.dxc5 ♙xc5

7...dxc4 8.♚c2 takes us a long way ahead to variation A of Chapter 16 – see page 253.



8.cxd5!

8.a3 was recommended by Marin in his English repertoire book, but *GM 10* shows a good solution for Black. Without going into details, the fact that the knight has not yet gone to c6 helps Black.

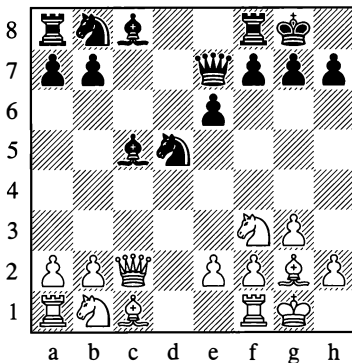
8...exd5

A lesser option for Black is:

8...exd5 9.♖c2! ♕e7

9...♖c7 10.♘c3 ♘d7 11.♙d2 is clearly better for White. 11...♙b4 occurred in the most recent game, Romanov – Ippolito, Philadelphia 2012, and now the simple 12.♞ac1± would have given White an obvious advantage.

9...♙e7 10.♞d1 ♖a5 11.♙d2 ♖c5 12.♘c3 12...♘xc3 13.♙xc3 ♖b6 Ladanyi – Kelemen, Budapest 2005, and after 14.♘e5!N White would claim an overwhelming advantage.



10.a3 ♘c6 11.b4 ♙b6 12.♙b2

Here too, White seizes an obvious advantage with simple and natural moves.

12...♙d7 13.e4 ♘f6 14.e5 ♘d5 15.♘bd2 ♞ac8 16.♖e4!

White has a pleasant space advantage and good chances to seize the initiative on the kingside, Bezold – Lipinsky, Budapest 1997.

9.♖c2!?

An important moment. The inevitable development of the black knight to c6 will

complete the transposition to the Tarrasch Defence. As mentioned before, I do not intend to recommend the old main lines with g2-g3 against the pure Tarrasch move order, so the present variation presented a real challenge. Fortunately, I found a good way to make use of the delayed development of the b1-knight. First the queen attacks the enemy bishop, while making room for the rook to go to d1 if needed.

9...♙b6

Other moves are inadvisable for Black. Certainly 9...♖b6? should be avoided, as 10.♘c3 threatens a fork on a4. After the further 10...♙d7 11.♙g5 Black already had serious problems with the d5-pawn in Andriessen – Rietveld, Alkmaar 1982.

9...♙e7 10.♞d1 ♘c6 11.♘c3

The isolated pawn and X-ray along the d-file render Black's position unpleasant.

11...♖a5

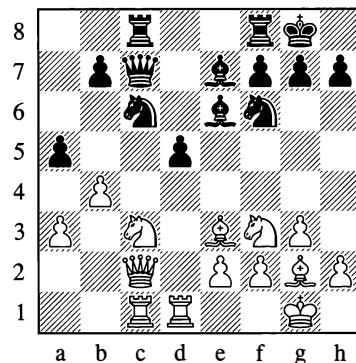
I would also like to mention: 11...♙e6 12.♘g5! h6? (12...♞c8 13.♘xd5! ♙xd5 14.♞xd5! is given in *GM 10*) This was Izzat – Kowsarinia, Kigali 2011, and now 13.♙xd5!N would have won material.

12.♙e3 ♙e6 13.a3!

The black queen is unstable on a5.

13...♞ac8 14.b4 ♖c7 15.♞ac1 a5

Now in Ribli – Lalic, Sarajevo 1985, White missed a powerful idea.



16.♘g5! N axb4

16...h6 17.♗xe6 fxe6 18.♕h3 is also excellent for White.

17.♗xd5 ♙xd5 18.♕xd5 ♖a5

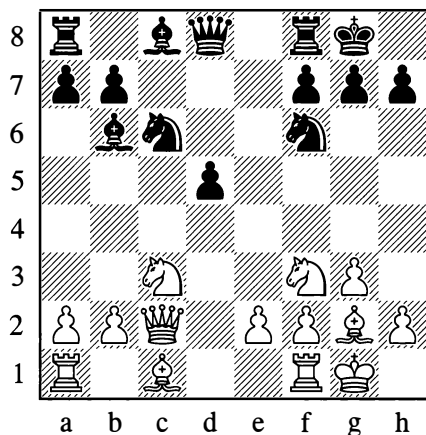
18...bxa3 loses by force: 19.♕xf7! ♖xf7 20.♗xf7 ♗xf7 21.♖b3! ♗f8 22.♕f4 ♖a5 23.♖xb7+–

19.axb4 ♖xb4 20.♕b3

White is clearly better.

10.♗c3 ♗c6

10...h6 11.♗a4 ♗c6 transposes to 11...h6 in the note to Black's next move below.



11.♗a4!

The more common 11.♕g5 ♕e6 is analysed in *GM 10*. The text move has only been played once out of more than thirty games, but it is the most accurate choice, as White avoids committing the bishop prematurely.

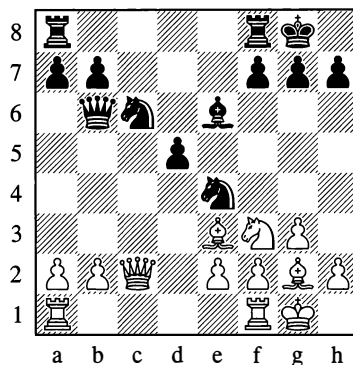
11...♕e7

This is an obvious candidate and it was Black's choice in the only game, so I will take it as the main line. Nevertheless, giving up the dark-squared bishop is quite a common theme in the Tarrasch, so I considered some other moves, a couple of which may soon transpose to existing games.

11...♖e8N 12.♗xb6 ♖xb6 (12...axb6 13.♕e3

also looks advantageous for White) 13.♕g5! Provoking the knight jump to e4 is a common theme to weaken the d5-pawn. 13...♖e6 (13...♗e4 14.♕e3! d4 15.♗xd4! ♗xd4 16.♖d3 White is clearly better) 14.b3 h6 15.♕c1! White will slowly establish control over the blocking d4-square.

11...♕e6 12.♗xb6 ♖xb6 (12...axb6 13.♖d1 clearly favours White; it is worth mentioning that 13.♕g5 h6 transposes to analysis in *GM 10*, so you can see how White benefits from keeping the bishop flexible) 13.♕g5! ♗e4 14.♕e3



14...♖a6 (Black is forced to move his queen, as 14...d4 is not possible now that the knight has been lured to e4) 15.b3 (15.♖d3!? is also worth considering) 15...♕g4 16.♖b2 ♖fe8 17.♖fe1 White obtained a stable positional advantage in Malaniuk – Giorgadze, Odessa 1989.

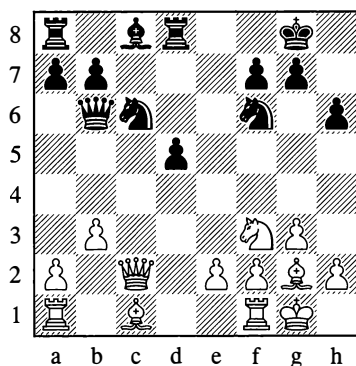
11...h6 12.♗xb6 ♖xb6

12...axb6 opens the a-file but further weakens Black's pawn structure. A good illustrative game continued: 13.♖d1 ♕g4 14.♕e3 ♖e8 15.h3 ♕xf3 16.♕xf3 ♖xe3?! A desperate attempt to change the character of the game. 17.fxe3 ♖c7 18.♗g2+ Black failed to prove his compensation in Wojtaszek – Shkapenko, Gorzow 2012.

13.b3 ♖d8

13...♙e6 occurred in Gajewski – Koch, Hagenau 2013. Here White could have played 14.♙e3!N, as 14...d4 can be met by 15.♘xd4! ♘xd4 16.♚b2 ♘xe2† 17.♚xe2, when White gets a pleasant edge thanks to his bishop pair.

Now in Lazarev – T.L. Petrosian, Lausanne 2005, White should have gone for simple development with:



14.♙b2 ♘e4

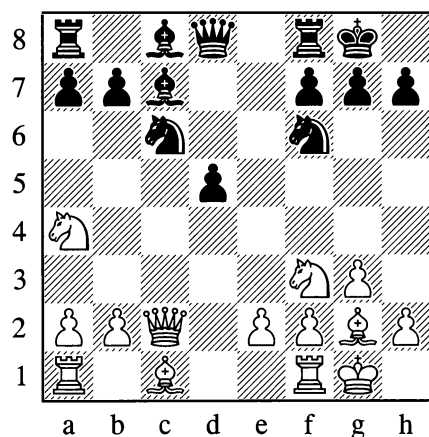
14...d4? just loses the pawn: 15.♚ad1 ♙e6 16.♚d3±

15.♚ad1 ♙f5 16.♘d4 ♙g6 17.♚c1

17.♘xc6 bxc6 18.♙d4 also deserves attention.

17...♚ac8 18.♚a1±

White has a stable advantage, thanks to his control over the d4-square and of course the bishop pair.



12.♙e3!N

12.♚d1 was played in Jumabayev – Senador, Al-Ain 2012, but I was not altogether happy with the position that might have arisen after 12...♚e8N, so I found a new concept.

12...♚e8 13.♚d3!

White had better prevent the possible exchange sacrifice, which might prove effective after 13.♚ac1 ♚xe3 14.fxe3 ♚e7∞. After the text move, I believe a logical sequence is:

13...♙g4 14.♚ac1 h6

14...♚c8 15.h3 ♙h5 16.♙g5! is clearly inferior for Black.

15.♚fd1 ♚c8 16.a3

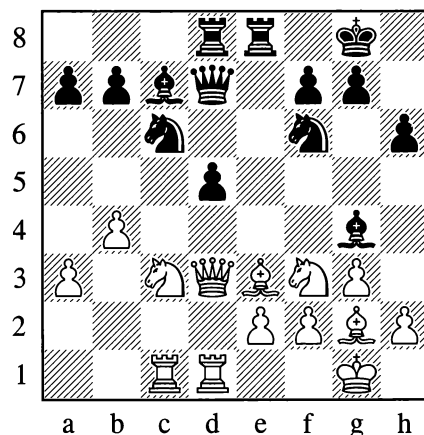
White has completed development and should retain a slight but pleasant advantage in all lines. I will offer a few brief examples:

16...♚e7

16...♙b8 17.♘c3 ♙e6 18.b4 ♚d7 19.♚d2±

17.♘c3 ♚cd8 18.b4 ♚d7

18...♙xf3 is well met by 19.♙c5 ♙d6 20.♙xd6 ♚xd6 21.exf3! followed by f3-f4, when the d-pawn will come under serious pressure.



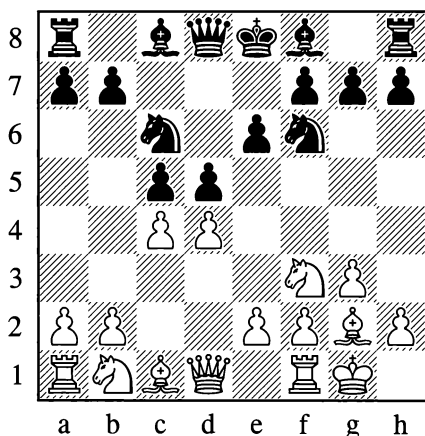
19.♙c5! ♙f5

After 19...b6 20.♙e3± Black's pieces on the c-file have been destabilized.

20.♟d2 ♙h3 21.♙h1±

The position remains complex, but White is better for sure.

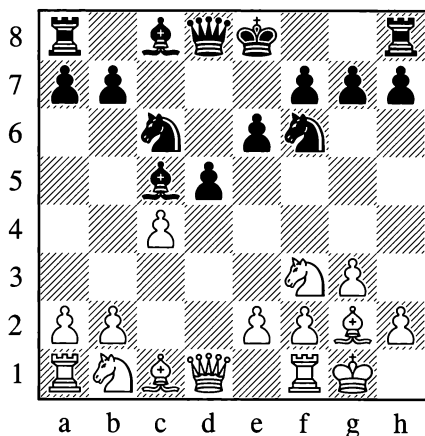
C2) 5...♘c6 6.0-0



This is an important branching position, where Black's two main tries are **C21) 6...♙e7** and **C22) 6...cxd4**.

6...dxc4 is another significant option, but it immediately transposes to a major variation of the Catalan, coverage of which begins in variation B of Chapter 6 on page 80.

C21) 6...♙e7 7.dxc5 ♙xc5



8.a3!?

If you compare this position to variation C1 above, you will see that I rejected the a2-a3 plan in that line. However, with the black knight already committed to c6, the b2-b4 idea has a bit more bite, so I decided to cover it here.

I should mention that 8.cxd5 is a good alternative. The most likely continuation is 8...exd5 9.♟c2 ♙b6 10.♘c3 0-0, reaching the same Tarrasch transposition as in variation C1 above. Black can try 8...♘xd5 instead, but 9.♟c2 looks promising for White, who has scored heavily from this position. In short, 8.cxd5 is a decent alternative which you may consider more convenient, but I decided to cover another option to give you a pleasant choice.

8...0-0

Black has tried several other moves, but in most cases White gets an easy advantage by developing his pieces on natural squares.

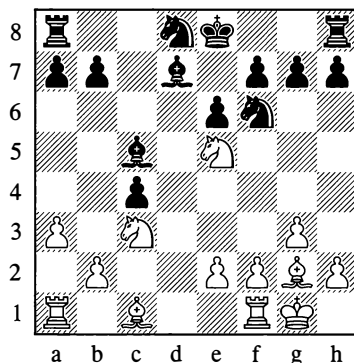
One way for Black to alter the character of the game is:

8...dxc4 9.♟xd8† ♘xd8

9...♙xd8 is worse: 10.♘bd2 c3 11.bxc3 ♙e7 12.♘b3 ♙d6 13.♘fd4 ♙d7 (13...♘xd4 14.cxd4 ♙d8 15.♙d2±) 14.♘b5 ♙e5 15.a4 Black was already under significant pressure in Koehyev – Yurenko, St Petersburg 1999.

10.♘e5 ♙d7 11.♘c3!

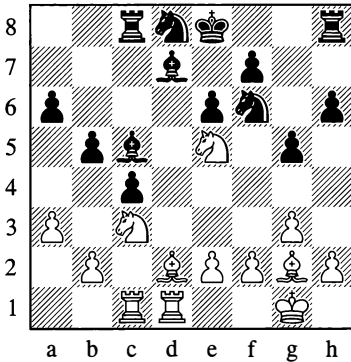
11.♘xc4 ♙b5 is not so bad for Black.



11...♖c8 12.♞d1 h6!?

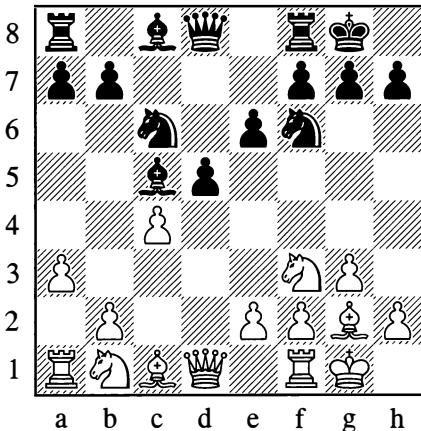
This was played in a remarkable game.

I also considered 12...♙c6N 13.♜xc4 ♙xg2 14.♜xg2 ♙e7 15.♜e5 ♜c6 16.♜xc6 ♖xc6 17.♙f4 0-0 18.e4 when, despite the simplifications, White retains solid pressure. 13.♙f4 g5 14.♙d2 a6 15.♖ac1 b5



16.♙e1! ♖h7 17.a4 b4 18.♜e4 ♜xe4 19.♖xd7 ♜d6 20.♖d1+

Black was crushed in Sharpe – Sibbald, corr. 2014.



9.b4 ♙b6

The following alternative has been more popular, but it has scored less than 25% for Black:

9...♙e7 10.♜bd2!

It is important to get the move order right.

The more common 10.♙b2 allows 10...dxc4!

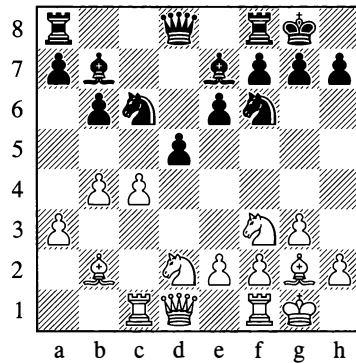
11.♞c2 ♙d7 12.♞xc4 ♖c8 when White's advantage is minimal.

After the text move Black's position is surprisingly unpleasant, due to his spatial inferiority and difficulty coordinating his pieces. I will mention a couple of plausible continuations.

10...b6

10...♙d7 11.♙b2 ♖c8 12.♖c1 a6 13.♜b3! dxc4 14.♖xc4 ♜b8 15.♖xc8 ♞xc8 occurred in Kengis – Ginsburg, Zürich 2003. Now the most accurate would have been 16.♞d2N ♙c6 17.♖c1 ♞d8 18.♞xd8 ♙xd8 19.♜fd2! ♙xg2 20.♜xg2♗ with an unpleasant endgame for Black, as White's queenside initiative is rather serious.

11.♙b2 ♙b7 12.♖c1



12...dxc4

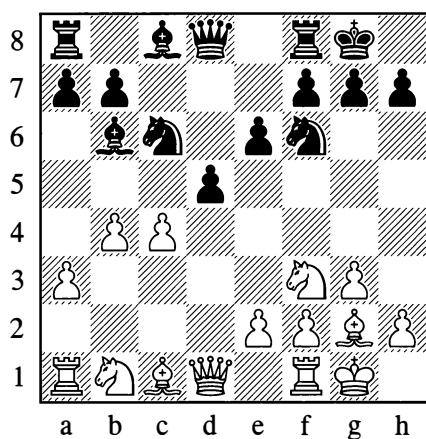
Another good example is: 12...♖c8 13.♞a4! White intends to increase the pressure with ♖fd1. Black tried 13...a5 in Kraai – Kavutskiy, San Diego 2009, and now the natural 14.b5N ♜b8 15.cxd5 ♖xc1 16.♖xc1 ♙xd5 17.♜d4 ♙xg2 18.♜xg2 would have retained definite pressure for White.

13.♜xc4 ♞xd1N

This is definitely a better try than 13...b5? 14.♜d4! ♜xd4 15.♙xb7 ♖b8 16.♜a5 when Black already had a lost position in Adhiban – Syed Anwar, Panaji 2012.

14.♖fxd1 ♖ac8 15.b5 ♜b8 16.a4±

Black is doomed to a passive defence.

**10. ♖b2!**

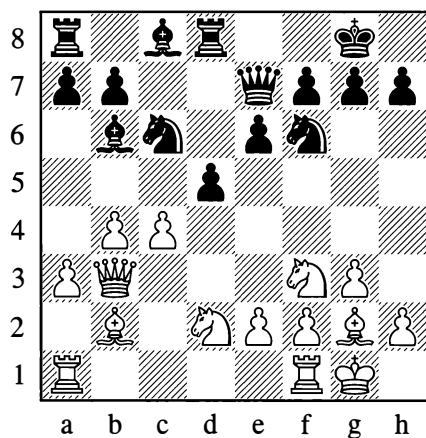
In contrast to the note above, 10. ♘bd2 would be inaccurate here due to 10...e5!.

10... ♗e7

10...dxc4 is no problem for White in view of 11. ♘bd2.

11. ♘bd2 ♜d8 12. ♗b3!N

For some reason almost everybody has played 12. ♗c2 instead, but after 12...e5 I am not so convinced by White's position.

**12...e5**

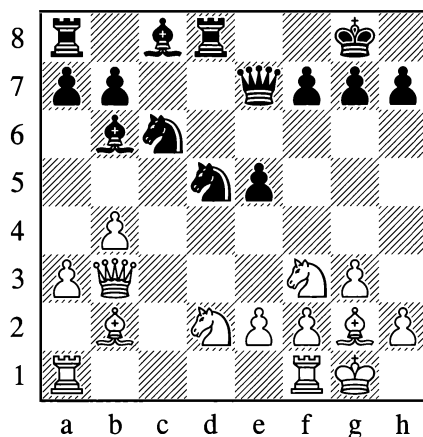
In view of the previous comment, it seemed logical to consider this move as the main line. If Black plays a quiet move then White

will simply develop his rooks and continue improving his position.

12...d4 is another attempt to force the play, but 13.c5 ♖c7 14.e3 is excellent for White: 14...e5 (14...dxe3 15. ♗xe3 ♘d5 16. ♗e4 f6 17. ♘c4 clearly favours White) 15.exd4 e4 16. ♘g5 ♘xd4 17. ♖xd4! ♗xd4 18. ♗b2 ♖e5 19. ♖ae1 Black loses his central pawn.

13.cxd5

13.b5 leads to interesting complications that seem to favour White, but one good line is enough.

13... ♘xd5**14.b5!**

After 14. ♘xe5 ♘xe5 15. ♖xd5 ♖e6 16. ♖xe6 ♗xd2 17. ♖xe5 ♗xe2 18. ♖xf7+ ♗xf7 19. ♗xf7+ ♗xf7 Black's active pieces should enable him to hold the endgame a pawn down.

14... ♘a5 15. ♗a4 ♖e6

Black has to sacrifice his e-pawn, as 15...f6? 16.e4 ♘c7 17. ♖c3 traps the knight on a5.

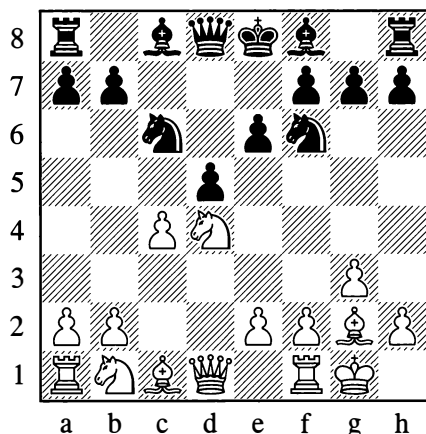
15...a6 16. ♘xe5 ♗e8 17. ♗h4 also favours White.

16. ♖xe5 ♗d7 17. ♘e4

Black does not have enough for the pawn.

C22) 6...cxd4 7.♘xd4

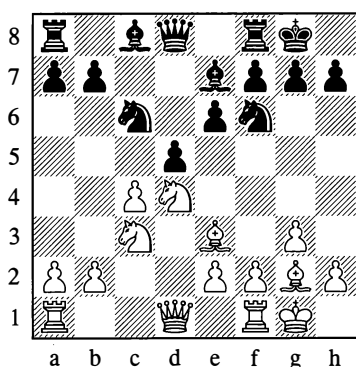
7.cxd5 is another decent option, but I would prefer to maintain the tension for a little longer.

**7...♙c5**

Less challenging is:

7...♙e7 8.♘c3 0-0 9.♙e3!

9.cxd5 exd5 leads to a version of the Tarrasch Defence where Black has exchanged on d4 prematurely. White should be better here too, but the text move seems even stronger.

**9...h6**

It is hard to know what to suggest for Black. 9...♘g4 10.cxd5 ♘xe3 11.fxex3 exd5 12.♘xd5 ♘e5 13.♙b3± White had an extra pawn and a powerful pair of knights in Modestov – Ananchenko, Samara 2003.

9...dxc4 was played in Ellers – Held, Fuerth 1998, and now 10.♙xc6! bxc6 11.♘xc6 ♙e8 12.♘xe7+ (12.♙a4!? is also interesting) 12...♙xe7 13.♙d4± gives White a lasting edge.

10.cxd5

There is nothing wrong with 10.♙c1, but the central exchange had become rather tempting, as Black's next move leads to a standard Tarrasch position with a full extra tempo for White.

10...exd5 11.♙a4! ♙d7

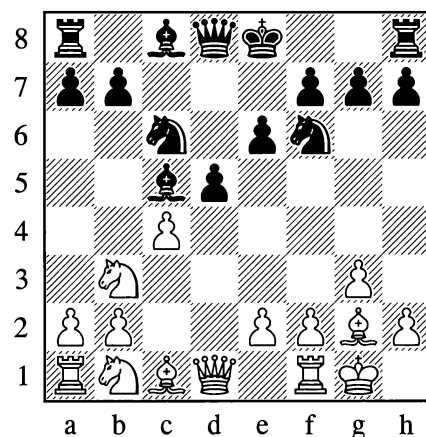
11...♘a5 12.♙c2! followed by ♙ad1 leads to a dream position for White.

12.♘xd5 ♘xd5 13.♙xd5 ♘b4 14.♙b3 ♙a5 15.♙f3±

White was a healthy pawn up in Benidze – Guliev, Malatya 2013.

8.♘b3

8.♘xc6 bxc6 9.♙c2 is an interesting alternative, which also gives White chances for an edge. However, it seems more logical to fight for an advantage with a move that does not involve strengthening Black's pawn centre.

**8...♙e7**

The alternative is:

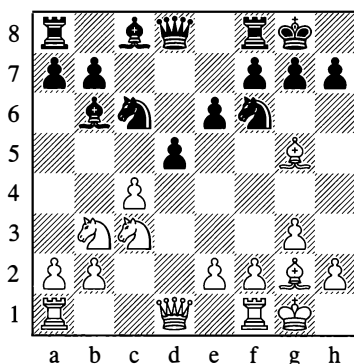
8...♙b6 9.♘c3!? 0-0

9...dxc4 10.♘d2 looks nice for White, as

trying to hold on to the extra pawn is too risky for Black: 10...♘a5 11.b4 cxb3 12.♙a3! ♙d7 13.axb3 ♙c6 14.b4 ♙xg2 15.bxa5 ♙xa5 occurred in Perez – Montiel, Havana 1993, and now 16.♘b5!N would have decided the game instantly.

10.♙g5

10.cxd5 ♘xd5 11.♘xd5 exd5 12.♖xd5 ♙g4 gave Black significant compensation for the pawn in Postny – Sebenik, Legnica 2013.



10...dxc4 11.♘d2 h6 12.♙xf6 ♖xf6 13.♘xc4 ♙c7

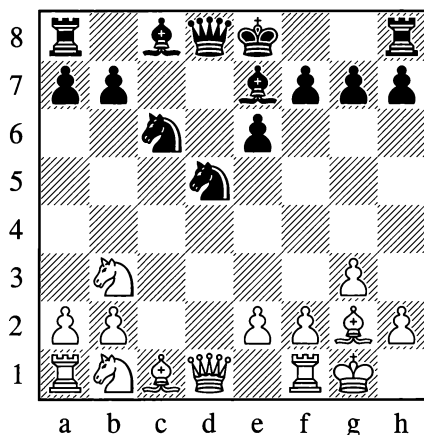
This position was reached in Dathem – H. Schmidt, corr. 1986, and another more recent correspondence game. White has good prospects on the queenside, and the only question is how best to develop his initiative. My suggestion is:

14.♖a4N ♙d7 15.♞fd1 ♞fd8 16.♖a3

With ongoing pressure.

9.cxd5 ♘xd5

9...exd5 10.♘c3 gives Black an unfavourable version of the Tarrasch, for instance: 10...♙e6 11.♙e3 0–0 12.♖d2 (12.♞c1 is also promising) 12...♖d7 (12...♘e5 is a better try, although White keeps the advantage after 13.♙d4N ♘c4 14.♖c2 followed by attacking the d5-pawn) 13.♞fd1 ♞fd8 14.♞ac1 ♘e5 15.♘c5 ♙xc5 16.♙xc5± White was clearly better in Karasek – Zavadil, Zlate Hory 2006.



10.♙d2!

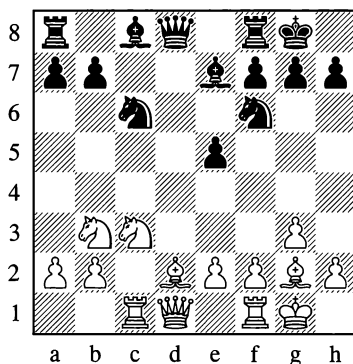
I believe this is the only way to fight for the advantage.

10...0–0

10...♙f6 11.♖c1! 0–0 12.♘c3 ♘xc3 13.♙xc3 e5 occurred in Burmakin – Laketic, Padova 2012, and here I see no reason to refrain from winning a pawn by means of 14.♙xc6N bxc6 15.♙b4 ♞e8 16.♖xc6.

11.♘c3 ♘xc3

11...♘f6 12.♞c1 e5 fails to solve Black's problems after:

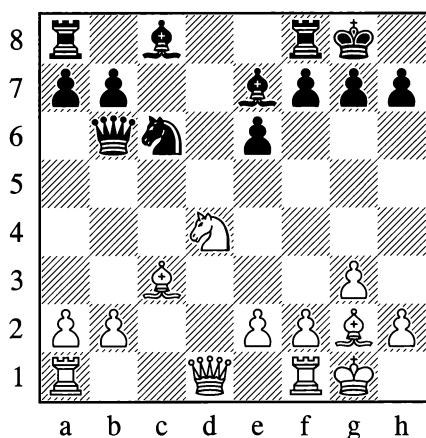


13.♙e3 ♙e6 14.♘c5 ♙xc5 15.♙xc5 ♖xd1 16.♞fxd1± when White's bishop pair is a powerful force.

11...♖b6 12.♗e4 ♘d5 13.♞c1 ♜b6 14.♞c2 h6 15.♗ec5± gave White solid pressure in Azmaiparashvili – Zaichik, Philadelphia 1991.

12.♙xc3 ♜b6 13.♗d4!

13.♞d3N ♞d8 14.♞e4 ♗d7 15.♞fd1± is a safe alternative which retains a pleasant advantage.



13...♞d8

This is the obvious way to challenge White's last move.

13...♗b4 14.a3 ♗d5 is a safer choice, when I propose: 15.♙xd5N (15.♗f5 is not so convincing, and after 15...♙f6 16.♙xd5 exd5 17.♞xd5 ♞d8 18.♞e4 ♙xf5 19.♞xf5 ♙xc3 20.bxc3 ♜c6 Black managed to hold his own in Mego – Pikus, corr. 2010) 15...exd5 16.♞d3± White has a small but stable edge.

14.♗xc6! ♞xd1 15.♗xe7† ♔f8 16.♞fxd1 ♔xe7 17.♞ac1 ♗d7 18.♙d4

White had a great position in Jankovic – Cebalo, Croatia 2013, with full material equality for the queen (once the b7- and/or g7-pawns fall) and a strong initiative.

Conclusion

4...g6 is an odd-looking move, but there is nothing much wrong with it, and after 5.♙g2 ♙g7 6.0–0 0–0 7.♞c2 we just have a typical Catalan situation except that Black's bishop is on an unusual square. White should be slightly better, as long as he avoids any early conflict in the centre, which might allow the g7-bishop to make its presence felt.

4...c6 is an important option, when 5.♙g2 ♗bd7 6.0–0 ♙d6 leads to a situation where the bishop on d6 has some pros and cons compared to the main Closed Catalan positions examined later in Chapter 15. White's most accurate move order is 7.♗d2! 0–0 8.♗c3, when the simple plan of e2–e4 is hard for Black to meet. 8...♙b4 is the only move that really gives White something to think about, but Black still falls short of equality.

Finally, 4...c5 is not such a popular move among strong players, but it forced me to think carefully about possible transpositions to the Tarrasch. After 5.♙g2 ♙e7 we ended up going down just such a path, but I found a good way to make use of the fact that ♗c3 had been delayed. 5...♗c6 6.0–0 reaches an important branching point, where I did not find equality for Black after 6...♙e7 or 6...cxd4. Of course Black can capture on c4 on move 5 or 6, but this leads straight to one of the Catalan variations that you can find in a later chapter.